



AUSTRALIA'S DEMOGRAPHIC SHIFT 1996 – 2016

MARKET INSIGHTS REPORT

GIA BAO HOANG

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Introduction

Australia's demographic has been transformed significantly over the past two decades, influenced by international immigration wave. Having a good understanding about this evolution and trends is important for public policy, resource allocation and national development. This report is going to present a thorough demographic analysis of Australian population, focusing on migrant origin people from 1996 to 2016.

The dataset is sourced from Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS), containing the estimated population by country of birth (COB), region, age and gender at 5-year census interval. The report uses Power BI dashboards to explore and present key demographic summary and aspects across various dimensions. To provide highlight of the population, top 10 countries of birth are chosen to analyse in the second part of the report.

The objective of the report is to provide informative insights into population trends, identify patterns and key shift in demographics which can be used for strategic planning. Three dashboards are created to give an interactive exploration and visualization to discover trends and potential insights. Screenshots from dashboards are used to provide examples of each visualization and how they can support the analysis.

Dashboard 1: Australia's Population Overview 1996 – 2016

This dashboard provides a snapshot of population trends in Australia from 1996 to 2016. It gives us a summary of insights regarding the changes in demographic statistics, particularly focusing on geographical distribution and regional movements in 20 years.

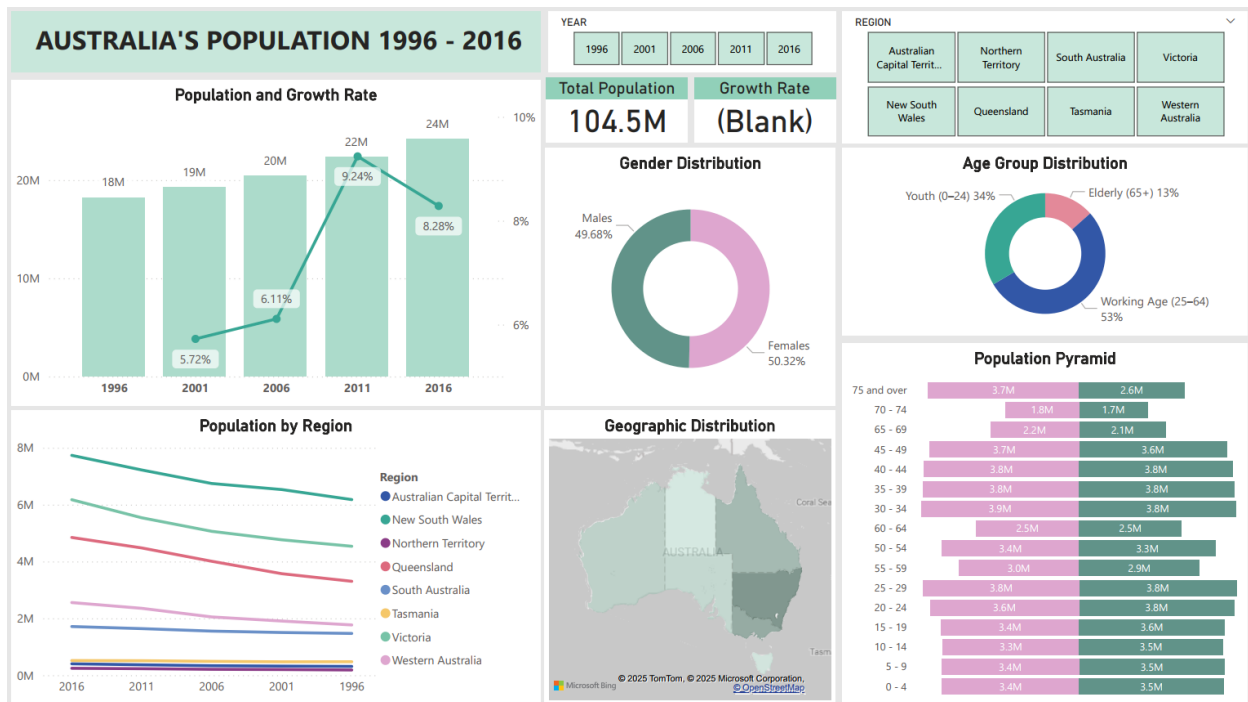


Figure 1. Dashboard 1 (without filter)

Steady growth: Australia's population increased by one-third

At the centre of the dashboard, total population and growth rate are showed, illustrating the steady increase trend in Australian population from 18 million in 1996 to 24 million in 2024. Supported by the bar chart on the left, it indicates the growth rate fluctuated every 5 years with slower rates from 1996 to 2006 (around 6%) after peaking at 9.24% from 2006 to 2011 and then slowing down again to

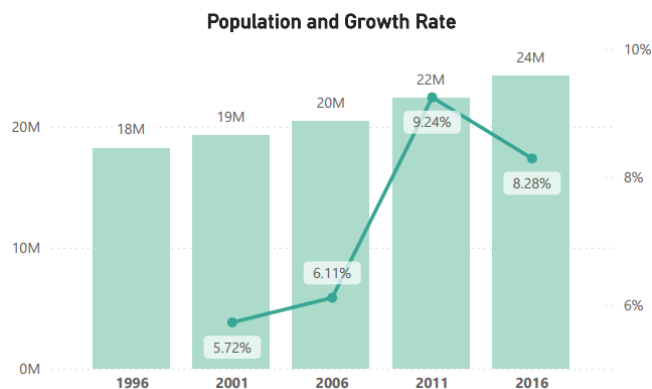


Figure 2. Population and Growth Rate 1996-2016

8.28% in the last period. These changes reflect the trends in fertility, urbanization and immigration during the period.

Balanced gender distribution

Gender distribution is another key aspect presented. The data shows a balanced split with 50.83% females and 49.62% males in 2016. By selecting year in the dashboard, we can see this split is unchanged thorough 20 years, which is typical for a developed country with stable birth and mortality.

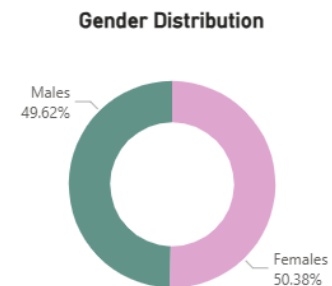


Figure 3. Gender Distribution in 2016

Working-age group domination

Working force group (25-64) represents the largest proportion of the population at 53% in 2016, following by Youth (0-24) at 32% and Elderly (65+) at 15%. This structure has been stable with a small increase in Elderly from 12% in 1996 to 15% in 2016. This suggests a strong base of working force but also indicates a growing movement in retirement group in the near future.

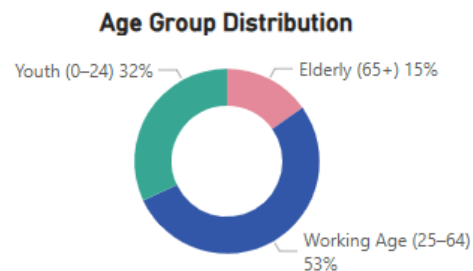


Figure 4. Age Group Distribution in 2016

Stable population pyramid

The population pyramid provides a closer view of age-gender distribution data. In 1996, the age distribution was broader at the baseline, showing a younger population. Over time, the pyramid narrows at the younger age brackets and starts widening in the older age groups, especially in the 55+ age groups in 2016. It demonstrates low birth rates and increased life expectancy; both contribute to a growing proportion of elderly. This shift confirms the aging of Australia's population which has a huge impact on healthcare system, aged care services, pensions and future workforce.

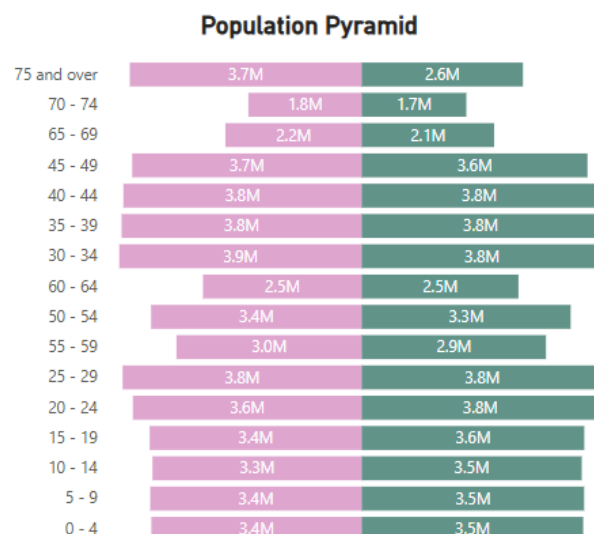


Figure 5. Population Pyramid

Urban concentration: Growth in Eastern states

A line chart is used to track population distribution across Australia's states and territories from 1996 to 2016. It reveals that New South Wales and Victoria consistently have the highest populations, while Western Australia and Queensland also have increasing trends. However, other smaller regions like Tasmania, Northern Territory and Australian Capital Territory maintain a low population level but still show upward trends.

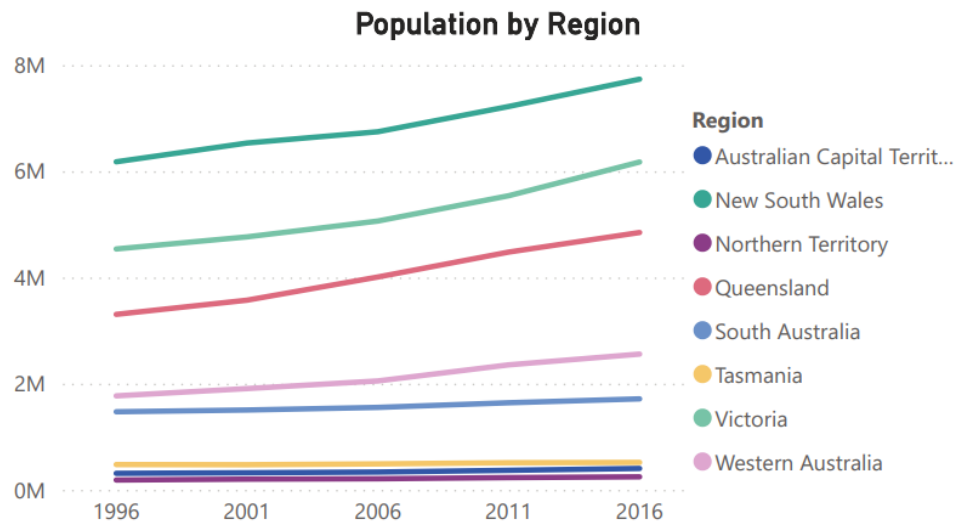


Figure 6. Population by Region (click on Region in the dashboard to see the movements)

From the dashboard, it shows that Victoria took over Queensland to become the second most popular states after New South Wales in 2011. These trends reflect the urban migration and international immigration, impacting on the economy and education systems.

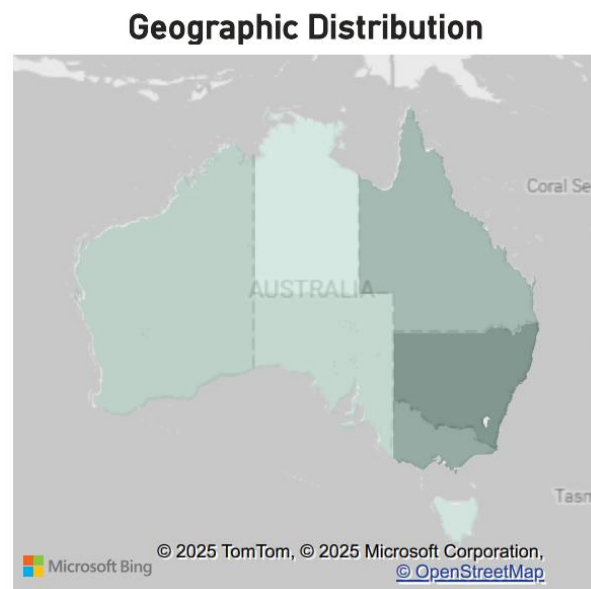


Figure 7. Geographic Distribution in 2016

The interactive map supports the regional analysis by visualizing the geographic distribution. Major cities like Sydney, Melbourne and Brisbane are in the eastern and southern coastlines where has high density in the map. These areas are the destination for both domestic and international migration due to employment, infrastructure and education opportunities.

In general, this dashboard shows an insightful summary of Australia's population from 1996 to 2016. It illustrates the demographic trends and movement which can support decision makers in investing and developing the infrastructure, housing system, transportation and public services.

Dashboard 2: Demographic Distribution of Top 10 Countries of Birth in Australia 1996 – 2016

Australia has been a multinational and multiracial country with increasing numbers of foreign born. In this section, we focus on analyse the distribution of Top 10 countries of birth (COB) including Australia and nine overseas nations. These countries have a huge influence and contribution to the immigration trends in Australia and to the diverse culture of the country. The selected countries are from Asia (China, Vietnam, India, ...), Europe (England, Italy, Greece) and other regions, allowing for a comprehensive comparison across multiple dimensions.

This dashboard illustrates how the population changes of selected COBs from 1996 to 2016.

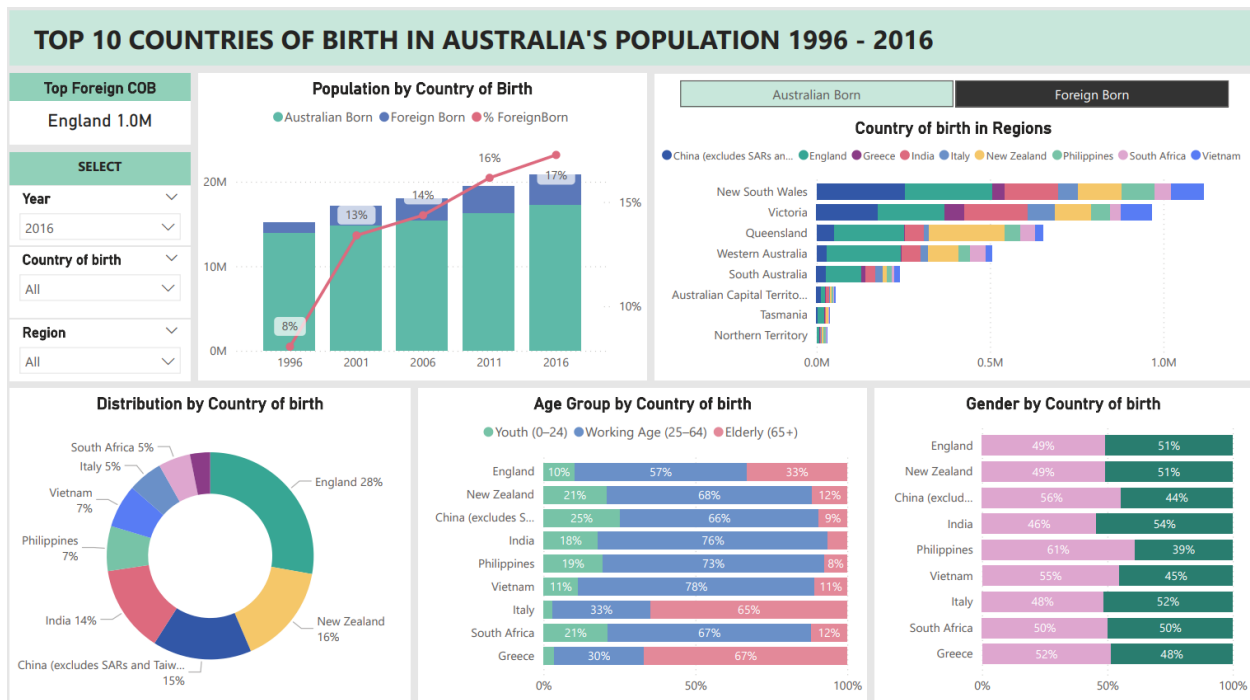


Figure 8. Dashboard 2 (for 2016)

Foreign-born growth outpaced Australian-born

The key trend from this chart is the increase of foreign born in Australia's population for 20 years. The percentage of foreign born rises dramatically from 8% in 1996 to 13% in 2011, then gradually up to 17% in 2016. By checking the trends for each COB, we can see a significant rise in population from China, India and Philippines, showing the shift in immigration from Asia in the past 2 decades. In contrast, the number of migrant origin from Mediterranean like Italy and Greece has declined seriously. Australian origin is consistently the highest growing with a steady pace.

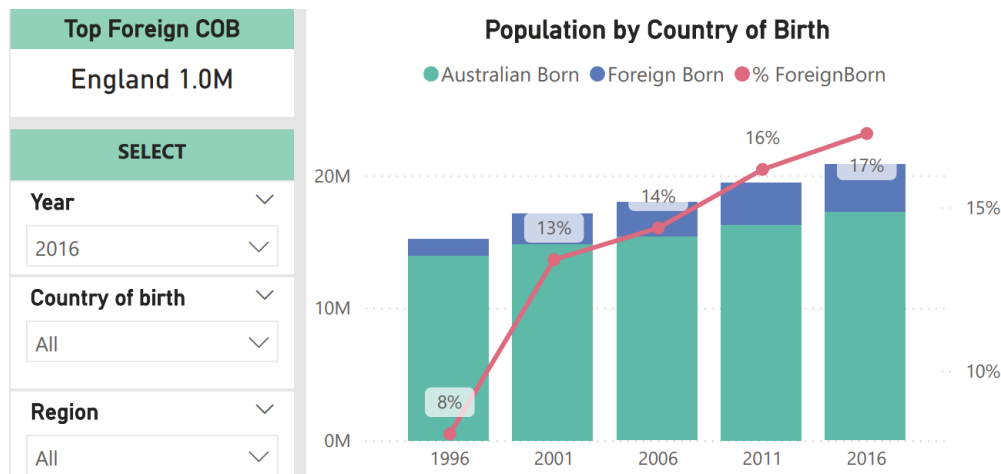


Figure 9. Total population by Count of birth and Top foreign COB in 2016

Young Asian-born threatening aging European-born

In this section, by reviewing the distributions throughout 5 periods, we can compare the distribution of foreign-born population by country of birth and discover a clear shift in Australia's immigration landscape. In 1996, European countries like Italy (20%), Greece (11%) and New Zealand (25%) contributed more to the foreign-born demographic. However, by 2016, it shows a remarkable decline in the share of these countries. While England started to be top 1 in migrant origin from 2001 with 40% and remains the top foreign country in 2016, this status is likely to be threatened over time, likely in the near to mid-term by Asian origin people. There is significant ground gained by Asian countries with Indian increasing from 7% to 14%, China from 10% to 13%.

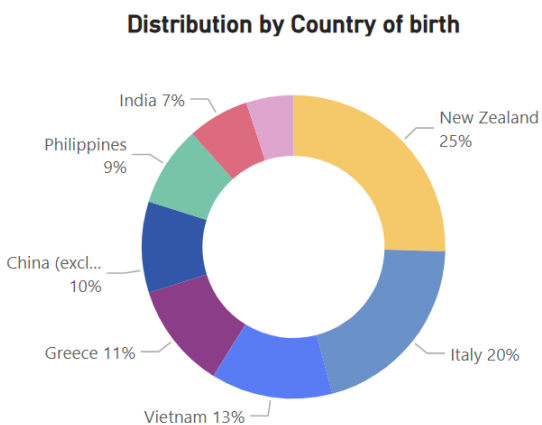


Figure 10. Distribution by foreign country of birth 1996

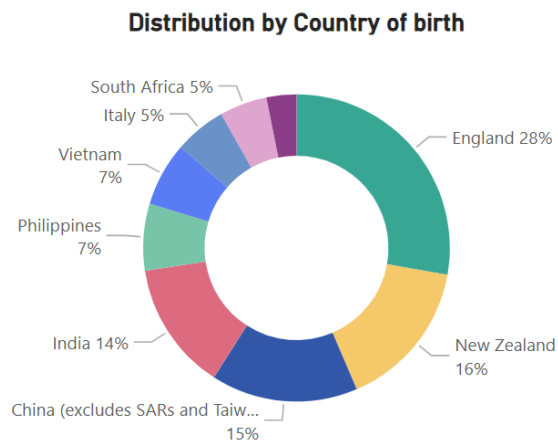


Figure 11. Distribution by foreign country of birth 2016

Age distribution reveals that the foreign-born population tend to contain more people in working-age group (25-64 years old) in most of countries in top 10 except for England, Italy and Greece. Italy and Greece maintain a high number of elderly throughout 20 years at 31% and 19% in 1996 to 65% and 67% in 2016, indicating aging migrant communities with a lower inflow. Newer migrant groups like China, Indian, Vietnam has contributed highly to the working force with over 70% during the whole period.

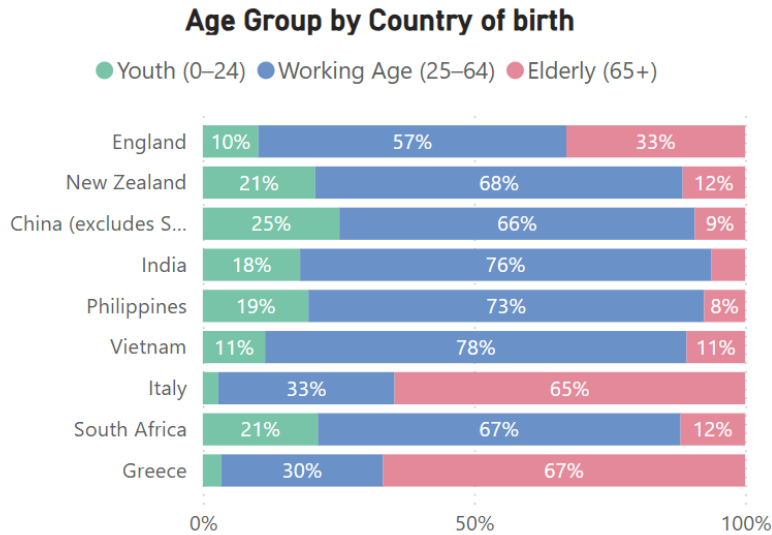


Figure 12. Age Group by Country of birth 2016

Gender composition diverged by origin

Gender distribution is generally balanced among most COBs with small variations appearing in certain countries. It seems like being influenced by the immigration patterns related to labor demand, for example, China and Philippines always have a higher proportion of females throughout 20 years.

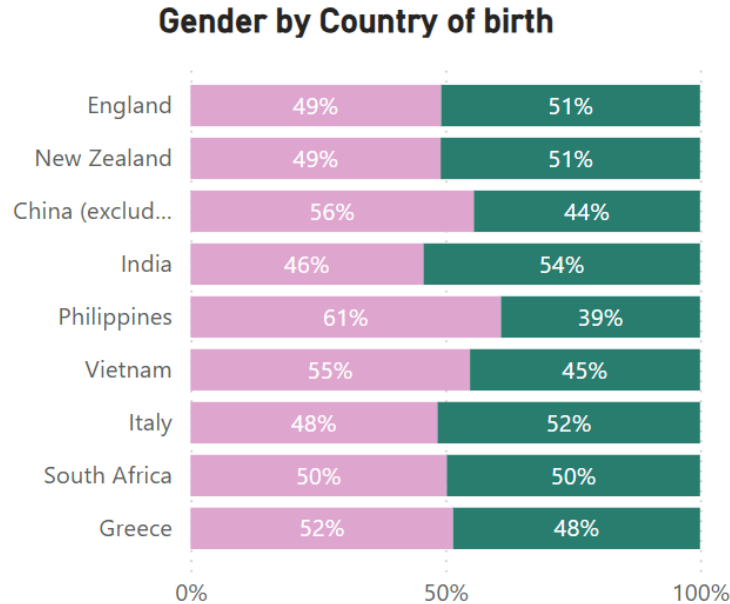


Figure 13. Gender by Country of birth 2016

Foreign-born settlement in cosmopolitan states

Major states with cosmopolitan cities tend to attract more diverse foreigners and this trend plays out in New South Wales and Victoria, with major cities of Sydney and Melbourne respectively.

Queensland and Western Australia also show a noticeable rise, particularly for English speakers like England and New Zealand.

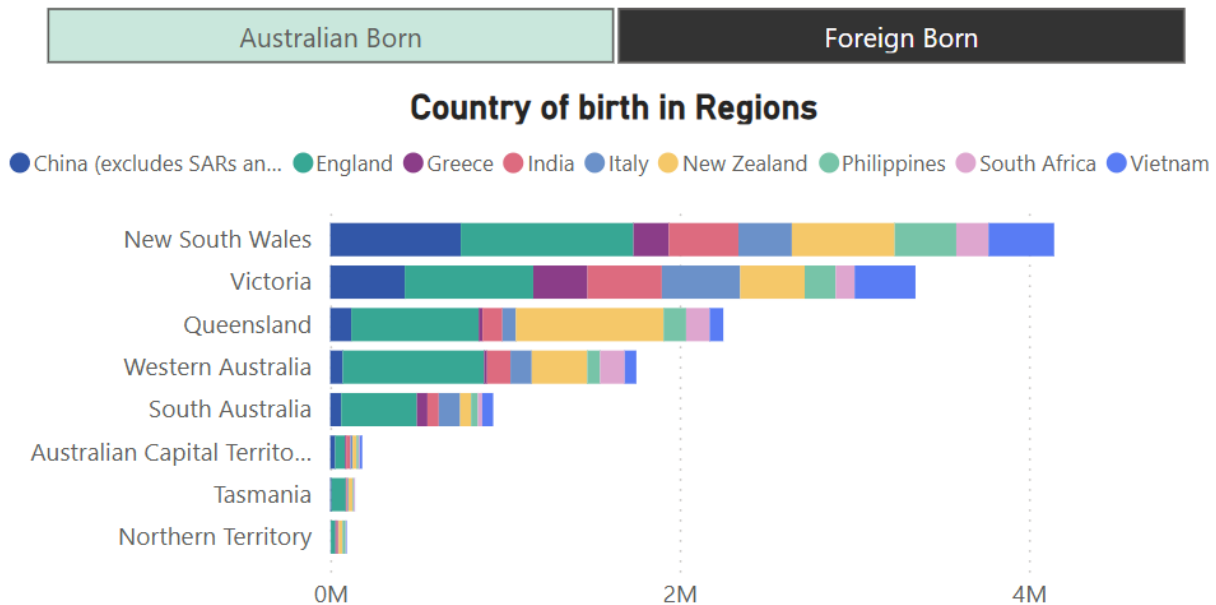


Figure 14. Country of Birth in Regions in 2016

To connect and summary the analysis in Dashboard 2, the demographic picture clearly shows the multicultural of Australia and a shift in migration pattern over the past 2 decades. It highlights the increasing of migrant origin, as well as how they reshape Australia's social and economic. This dashboard also reveals a shift in migration from European countries like Italy, Greece to Asian based nations like China, India and Philippines.

Overall, the comparative insights from this dashboard demonstrates a diversified population of Australia and provide an important context for future immigration, social inclusion and workforce planning. If governments fail to respond on changing population, urban areas could become overloaded and the gap between generations might widen. While young migrants moving to Australia bring a lot of economic potential, they need specific support to settle in. Meanwhile, older residents will require more support and aged care. To keep the country strong, future planning and infrastructures need to focus on local needs, respect different cultures, and ensure long-term development.

Dashboard 3: Shifting in Migrant Origin of Australian Population 1996 – 2016

We have noticed an exponential growth of immigrants of Asian origin the previous section, where many Asian countries appear in top 10 countries of birth in Australia population. Dashboard 3 will be used to analyse the shift in migrant origin from Europe to Asian from 1996 to 2016 in both population size and workforce contribution.

European migrants largely tend to come from England, which may be largely due to historical links between the two countries, and with Australia still being part of the Commonwealth. On the other hand, Asian migrants are more diversified, with large numbers coming from China and India, followed by Philippines and Vietnam, reflecting a large variation of cultures and lifestyles in the major cities.

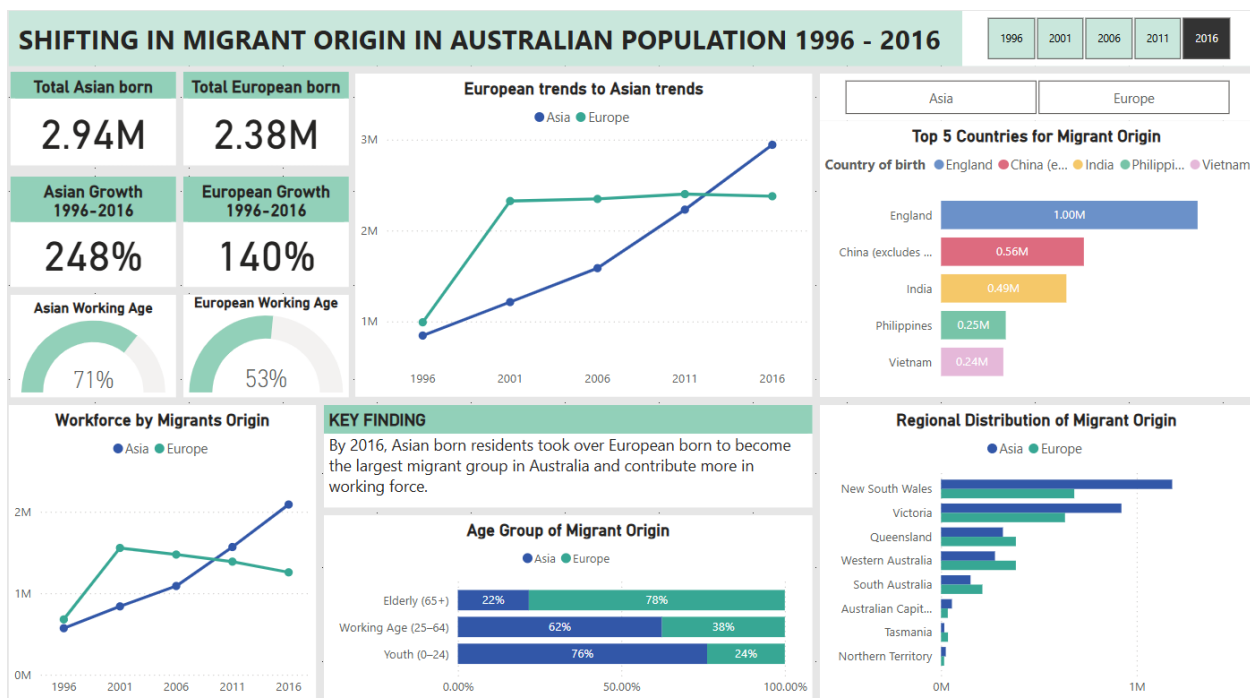


Figure 15. Dashboard 3 (in 2016)

Migration shift: Asian surpass European

As we can see from the line chart, there is a steady growth in the Asian born population for 20 years. Conversely, we note a downward trend of immigrants of European origin from 2001 onwards, contrasting a sharp spike in the preceding 5 years from 1996 to 2001. The growth rate of Asian born is 248% from 1996 to 2016 reaching 2.94 million comparing to 140% growth rate of European born with 2.38 million in 2016.

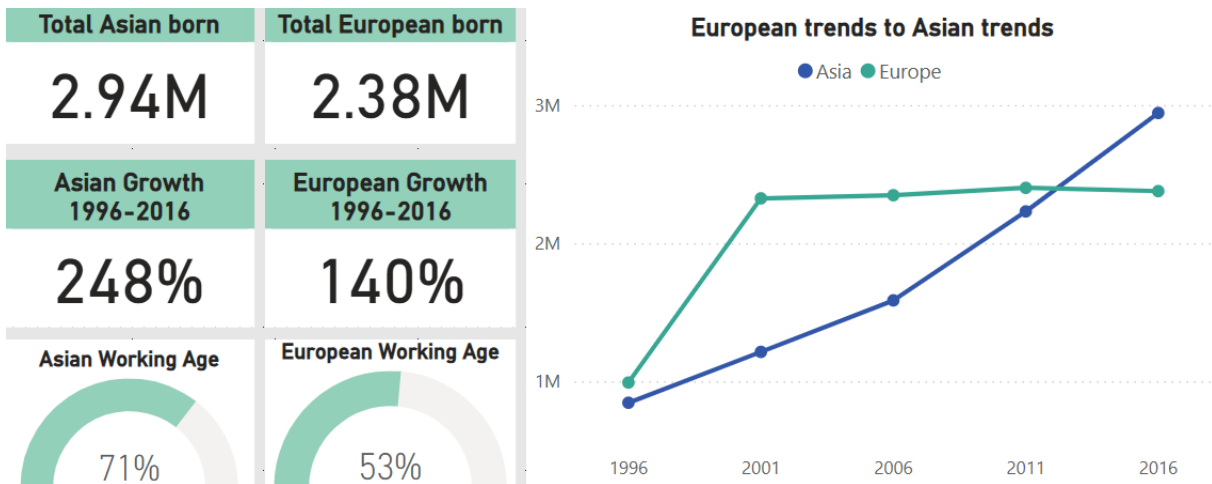


Figure 16. European trends to Asian trends and Total number in 2016

This trend demonstrates the change in immigration policies that attracted people from developing Asian countries like Vietnam and Philippines, as well as economic powerhouse like China and India. Educational opportunities are also drawing young Asian migrants to Australia.

Statistical Insights: Working-age force from Asia countries

The vast majority of Asian immigrants are of working age (62% in the working age bracket in 2016), with a likely propensity to increase in numbers through family growth, which correlates with the increasing percentage of foreign born. Huge wave of Asian youths, which would increase the proportion of working age adults from that segment over time.

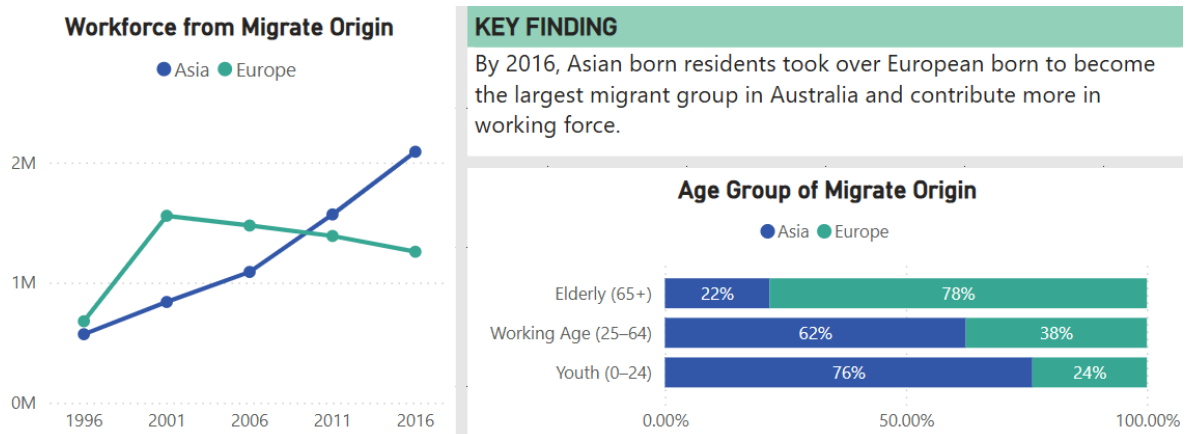


Figure 17. Age Group Distribution and Workforce Comparison in 2016

It is also notable that that European migrants tend to be older in age, with the vast majority of elderly migrants of European origin (78%), which is a stark contrast for other younger age groups where Asian migrants take a larger share. This shows that Asian migrants contribute more actively to the workforce, which has a strong positive impact to the economic planning and labor force sustainability in an aging society.

State-level distribution: Asia domination in Eastern states

Asian migrants also have a distinct preference for the states which are more metropolitan in nature - with many mostly headed to the states of New South Wales and Victoria - more likely in part to major urban centers of Sydney and Melbourne.

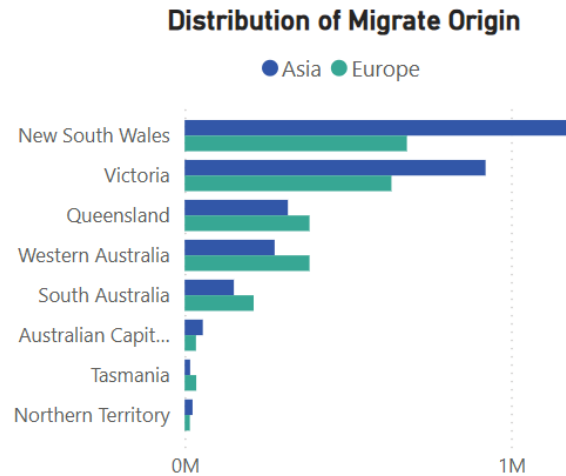


Figure 18. Regional distribution of Migrant Origin in 2016

Recommendations

Recognizing these demographic shifts is important for Australian governments to adapt and take advantage of for the country's development.

First, to maximize the potentials of working-age migrants, especially from Asian countries, governments should expand Migration Strategy 2023 to include more practical skill recognition frameworks. Reducing administration hurdles for foreign qualification assessments can prevent “brain waste”, where skilled migrants are trapped into low-productivity sectors (CEDA, 2024). Moreover, bridging programs, English programs and cultural mentorships can ensure these migrants can immediately contribute to high-demand industries like healthcare, education and digital technology, effectively addressing critical workforce shortage (Department of Home Affairs, 2023).

Second, the combination of an ageing European migrant community and a rising domestic elderly base requires immediate expansion of aged care facilities, community support programs and culturally appropriate care models. CEDA (2025) suggests some effective solutions including the implementation of an “Essential Skills Visa” that bypasses complex labor market testing and reduce upfront sponsorship cost for providers and a broader Migration Strategy expansion which create a more agile workforce pipeline. These domestic wage improvements and technology-driven “aging-in place” initiatives can ensure the sector maintain quality care without placing an unsustainable burden on the younger workforce.

Finally, population concentration in NSW and Victoria requires proactive investment in infrastructure, transportation, housing supply and public services to prevent bottlenecks which slow economic growth. By integrating private sectors at the early stages of planning, states can leverage commercial expertise and innovative capabilities to supplement public investment (Infrastructure NSW, 2022). Furthermore, satellite cities can provide a visible solution for affordable rental housing by high-speed transport links that ensure connectivity to capital city centres (Pill et al., 2020).

Conclusion

This report provides a comprehensive analysis of Australia's population from 1996 to 2016, focusing on total population growth, age and regional distribution and migrant trends. The data clearly demonstrates the significant shift within the composition of Australian demographics, as well as the origin of its migrants. The last two decade witnesses a substantial rise in migration from Asia, particularly from China, India, Philippines and others, contrasting with the previous European migration trend. This shift not only indicates the change in immigration policy and global mobility, but also impacts on national workforce, social services and the whole economy. The high number of younger migrants from Asia brings positive contribution to the workforce while the aging migrants from Europe can increase the demand for aged care and support systems. These insights are critical for policy making on every aspect of the country including urban planning, healthcare and education systems, housing and infrastructure, together with multicultural integration.

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